



Full Length Article

Civilian militia formation and protection against rebel violence: Evidence from Nigeria

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ABSTRACT

Why do some civilian defense militias effectively protect civilians while others fail and seem to only exacerbate rebel violence against civilians? Many irregular civil wars involve civilian defense militias, i.e., informal civilian groups that cooperate with the state military to protect their communities. Despite a burgeoning literature on militias in civil wars, research on variation in militia emergence and protective effects remains limited. Drawing on field research in northeastern Nigeria's Boko Haram conflict, we explain how local variation in militia formation shapes militias' protective effects against rebel violence. We argue that when repressive conflict conditions in state-dominated areas create incentives for civilian violent resistance, a community's collective action capacity, defined by local leadership and social cohesion, determines whether militias are community-initiated or imposed by state forces. Communities with high-capacity form *community-initiated militias* and maintain social control over their activities, which enables militias to effectively protect civilians against rebel violence. By contrast, communities with low capacity often host *state-initiated militias* and struggle to establish social control over their members, which renders them ineffective against rebels. Our findings contribute to a more nuanced understanding of civilian protective agency by showing that the capacities enabling neutrality and nonviolent resistance can also empower communities to form militias that effectively resist rebel violence.

1. Introduction

In June 2013, residents of Maiduguri, the capital of Borno State in northeast Nigeria, formed a civilian defense militia to protect themselves from the rebel group Boko Haram. Within months, the so-called Civilian Joint Task Force (CJTF) had driven Boko Haram out of the city and into surrounding rural areas. Inspired by Maiduguri's success, civilian defense militias quickly spread across Borno State as communities sought to emulate the CJTF (Agbiboa, 2021; Thurston, 2018). Alongside these grassroots efforts, state-directed militias also emerged, with military actors pressuring communities to contribute to counter-insurgency operations (CIVIC, 2018). This pattern is not unique to Nigeria. Across Syria, Mozambique, Cameroon, Guatemala, and Peru, some community-based militias emerged organically while others were imposed by the state (Agbiboa & Aniekwe, 2023; Bateson, 2017; Fumerton, 2001, 2018; Jentzsch, 2022; Voller, 2022). This variation raises broader questions about the contexts in which civilian militias emerge and how these contexts shape their protective effects.

A growing body of research explores how civilian defense militias shape civil war dynamics. Militias may reduce state violence by signalling alliance, aiding counterinsurgency efforts, and offering local knowledge (Bolte, 2021; Carey et al., 2022; Carey & Mitchell, 2017; Clayton & Thomson, 2016; Johnson & Wittels, 2023; Schubiger, 2021;

Shire, 2021). They also serve as low-cost force multipliers, providing both legitimacy and plausible deniability for state violence (Agbiboa, 2021; Biddle et al., 2012; Böhmelt & Clayton, 2018; Jentzsch, 2022; Koos, 2014; Peic, 2014). Yet, militia formation can provoke rebel retaliation and escalate violence against civilians (Aliyev, 2020; Clayton & Thomson, 2016; Jentzsch, 2023a; Jentzsch et al., 2015). Still, why some civilian defense militias succeed in protecting civilians while others fail or even exacerbate violence remains underexplored.

Civilians exposed to civil war adopt various self-protection strategies: some remain neutral or flee, others comply with the demands of armed actors, and some collectively organize to resist, either nonviolently or violently, by choosing sides and forming militias for protection (Jackson, 2021; Jentzsch & Masullo, 2022; Jose & Medie, 2015; Kaplan, 2017; Krause et al., 2023; Milliff, 2024). In Borno State, civilians employed all these strategies across locations and at different stages of the Boko Haram insurgency, but the formation of civilian defense militias proved more consequential, as it significantly altered conflict dynamics (Agbiboa, 2021; Bamidele, 2016; Hassan & Pieri, 2018). In some towns and villages, civilian defense militias effectively protected civilians from rebel violence, while in others, they failed and worsened the situation for civilians. We define civilian defense militias as "armed organizations that exist outside the formal security apparatus of the state; they emerge as counter-movements against insurgents either on

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the initiative of community residents or state representatives" (Jentzsch, 2022, p. 2). This definition excludes criminal groups, pro-ethnic militias, and rebel-affiliated forces. Following Jentzsch, we distinguish between community-initiated militias, which arise from grassroots collective action, and state-initiated militias, often imposed by state military forces (Jentzsch, 2022).

We start with fieldwork data showing that the same community characteristics that enable nonviolent civilian resistance also facilitate the emergence and effectiveness of militias. Using an iterative approach that toggles between theory and empirics (Kennedy & Thornberg, 2018; Schwartz-Shea & Yanow, 2012), we argue that repressive conflict conditions in state-dominated areas, characterized by rebel infiltration, indiscriminate state violence, and the erosion of civilian neutrality, create strong incentives for communities to form militias. When these conditions emerge, a community's collective action capacity, defined as the ability to mobilize around shared interests despite internal divisions (Rubin, 2020), shapes whether a militia is community-initiated or imposed by the state. While community capacity is multi-dimensional, we focus on two key dimensions: local leadership and social cohesion, which are essential for forming effective militias (Kaplan, 2017, p. 51). In high-capacity communities, strong local leadership and high social cohesion facilitate the formation of community-initiated militias that are deeply embedded in pre-existing local social structures and governed by informal social control. Such militias tend to be disciplined, motivated, and accountable, enabling them to gather intelligence, resist rebel infiltration, and elicit support from state forces. By contrast, low-capacity communities, marked by weak leadership and weak social cohesion, are more likely to host state-initiated militias imposed by state forces. These militias' haphazard recruitment of unfit residents and lack of community social control make them prone to civilian predation and intelligence leaks, rendering them less effective at protecting civilians and securing state cooperation.

We use a subnational research design focused on northeastern Nigeria during the initial wave of militia formation (2013–2015) because research has shown that rebel attacks on civilians are most intense during the early period of militia emergence (Clayton & Thomson, 2016). The years 2013–2015 preceded the widespread co-optation of community-initiated militias by the state, which often undermines community leaders' social control over militias (Voller, 2022).¹ Our theory-building is based on two months of fieldwork in 2022, including fourteen group interviews and twenty individual interviews with CJTF leaders, community elders, women leaders, residents, journalists, and civil society actors. We center our analysis on two cases: Biu, where community-leaders had formed an effective militia, and Bama, where the military had forced the community into forming a militia group. These towns were selected after a comprehensive review of larger communities based on preliminary interviews, conflict event data, and documents. Through this subnational research design, we examine how militia origins shaped their effectiveness. While the limited number of cases may constrain generalizability (Gerring, 2004), our findings may 'translate' to patterns of militia formation and effectiveness beyond Nigeria (Simmons & Smith, 2025).

Theoretically and empirically, this study contributes to three strands of scholarship. First, it deepens research on civilian agency in war (Jose & Medie, 2015; Krause et al., 2023), showing that traits linked to nonviolence, such as autonomy and neutrality (Kaplan, 2017), also predict the formation of protective militias. Second, it refines our understanding of civilian defense militias (Blocq, 2014; Clayton & Thomson, 2016; Jentzsch, 2022; Koos, 2014; Shire, 2021), demonstrating that

their protective effects depend on how they are formed and the extent of social control they wield. Finally, it contributes to the study of political violence (Gutiérrez-Sanín & Wood, 2017; Kalyvas, 2019), showing that militia formation in Borno shifted Boko Haram's tactics from targeted assassinations to large-scale attacks on unarmed civilians.

2. Existing research on civilian defense militias and militia formation

Studies of civilian defense militias in civil war have proliferated in recent years (Carey et al., 2022; Jentzsch et al., 2015; Johnson & Wittels, 2023). The term *civilian defense militia* is often used interchangeably with concepts such as vigilante groups or civilian defense forces to describe civilian groups that engage in community protection against rebels (Thomson, 2023). While civilian defense militias and vigilantes share similarities, they differ in important ways. Civilian defense militias emerge primarily in civil war settings and are defined by their opposition to rebel groups, whereas vigilantes typically operate outside of civil war and are distinguished by their focus on combating crime (Johnson & Wittels, 2023). When civilians participate in militias during war, they challenge conventional definitions of civilians in international law by blurring the distinction between combatants and non-combatants (See Melzer, 2009). Nevertheless, these groups can still be understood as civilian organizations, as civilians typically resort to armed resistance only when they perceive it as the most effective, or the sole, strategy for survival, often in the absence of alternative sources of protection (Jentzsch, 2022; Schubiger, 2021).

Existing research on civilian defense militias has largely focused on how their presence shapes patterns of state and insurgent violence against unarmed civilians. Scholars argue that such militias often signal alignment with the government and provide state forces with improved intelligence, thereby reducing state violence against civilians (Agbibo, 2021; Hassan & Pieri, 2018; Peic, 2014; Schubiger, 2021; Voller, 2023). Civilian defense militias also benefit from familiarity with local terrain, populations, languages, and customs, which they can leverage in countering rebel activity (Ashindorbe et al., 2021; Biddle et al., 2012; Fumerton, 2018; Koos, 2014). At the same time, they are often described as inexpensive force multipliers that provide governments with legitimacy and deniability for violence against unarmed civilians (Böhmelt & Clayton, 2018).

However, a parallel strand of research emphasizes the risks associated with civilian defense militia formation. The presence of civilian defense militias within civilian communities often increases conflict intensity and duration (Aliyev, 2020; Carey & González, 2021; Clayton & Thomson, 2016), and does not make government victory more likely (Carey et al., 2022). Militia formation by civilian communities also risks escalating rebel violence as they provide the intelligence to identify rebel members and discover hideouts (Carey et al., 2022), especially if some former insurgents switch sides and join pro-government militias (S. Otto, 2018). In response, rebel groups frequently target unarmed civilians to deter civilian defense militia formation, punish communities that have mobilized, and reassert territorial control (Agbibo, 2021; Bamidele, 2016; CIVIC, 2018; Clayton & Thomson, 2016). While these two strands of research explain why civilian defense militia formation can intensify violence, they do not account for variation in civilian defense militia formation itself or in militias' protective effects.

Beyond the specific focus on civilian defense militias, scholars studying militias more broadly distinguish among different types based on the strength of their ties to state sponsors (Bruin, 2023; Carey et al., 2013). Semi-official militias may be legally recognized, and members receive compensation. Examples include the Village Defense Committees in India and the Revolutionary Committees in Libya under Gaddafi (Carey et al., 2013). Informal militias lack a formalized link, even though their connection to the government may be widely acknowledged within the country. Examples include the Young Patriots in Cote d'Ivoire and the Interahamwe in Rwanda during the early 1990s (Carey

¹ Although many community-initiated militias are incorporated into state security structures or captured by political elites over time, recent work on *Comités de Autodefensa* in Peru shows that their trajectories can vary, with some assuming enduring governance roles in post-conflict contexts (See Taccone, 2025). Explaining such longevity lies beyond the scope of this article.

& Mitchell, 2017). In addition to the semi and informal category, De Bruin adds the category of “official militias” to capture armed groups under the government's direct administrative control but not within the military chain of command, such as the Peasant Guard in North Korea and the Volunteers for National Security in Haiti (Bruin, 2023).

Finally, broader research on militias has focused on the nature of militia emergence and professionalism, rather than on the nature of sponsorship or relationships to the state. Jentzsch introduces a key distinction between community-initiated and state-initiated militias, and between full-time and part-time forces (Jentzsch, 2022). Community-initiated militias are typically informal, part-time groups formed by local residents and traditional leaders for protection from insurgents. Examples include the Kamajors in Sierra Leone (Hoffman, 2011) and the Naparama in Mozambique (Jentzsch, 2022). In contrast, state-initiated militias are organized by state forces, with leaders often appointed by the military. These groups may be informal or semi-formal, depending on their level of integration and whether they are full-time or part-time. Full-time, state-directed militias like the Janjaweed in Sudan (Flint, 2009) and Syria's National Defense Force (Leenders & Giustozzi, 2019) are more professionalized. Part-time militias, such as Guatemala's civil patrols (Bateson, 2017), perform security duties alongside daily civilian activities. While these militias can support civilian protection by deterring rebel attacks and gathering intelligence, they also pose risks. Both community- and state-initiated militias may fragment, become predatory, or escalate violence, especially when conducting offensive operations or facing rebel retaliation (Jentzsch, 2023a; Shire, 2021). Shire attributes such shifts to opportunistic recruits seeking personal gain or settling local grievances (Shire, 2021).

Jentzsch and Shire offer important insights into militia formation but do not explain variation in civilian defense militias' protective effects. Our study addresses this gap. We compare community-initiated and state-initiated *informal militias* in two communities facing the same conflict. Both types of militias aim to protect civilians from the same rebel threat during the same period. We theorize and explain their varying protection impact.

3. Community capacity, militia formation, and protective effects

We develop our theoretical argument on variation in the formation and protective effects of civilian defense militias (hereinafter *militias*) through an iterative process between theory and empirics (Kennedy & Thornberg, 2018; Schwartz-Shea & Yanow, 2012). Our fieldwork data show that community-initiated militias are formed spontaneously, driven by resistance against Boko Haram insurgents. Due to their success, state forces eventually coerced residents in other towns and settlements to join informal militias formed by military forces. However, unlike their community-initiated counterparts, state-initiated militias were not effective in protecting civilians from Boko Haram violence. We build on inductive inferences from our fieldwork data and deductive insights from the literature on civilian agency, militias, and civil war to develop a causal process that explains how the nature of militia formation shapes their protective effects against rebel violence.

When rebellion begins in areas under state control, rebels typically avoid territorial capture and instead prioritize recruitment, surveillance, logistics, and sporadic attacks on state forces (Kalyvas, 2006; Lewis, 2020). Although some civilians may sympathize with rebels for ideological or personal reasons, broad community support is rare, and most civilians prefer neutrality (Kalyvas, 2006; Kaplan, 2017). Yet rebels' reliance on civilian cover blurs the distinction between combatants and non-combatants, rendering neutrality suspect to state forces, which also depend on civilian cooperation. State responses often involve sweeping counterinsurgency operations that disrupt daily life (Blocq, 2014; Sanda, 2020). Some communities initially adopt nonviolent resistance to signal non-alignment, but rebels may interpret this as betrayal and retaliate against civilians. Faced with both rebel retaliation and state repression, communities often resort to forming militias (Jentzsch,

2022; Schubiger, 2021).

However, while conflict conditions may incentivize the formation of militias, civilians must also possess the capacity to form militias that generate protective effects. We define protective effect as a militia's ability to mitigate or prevent direct insurgent violence against civilians within a locality (Clayton & Thomson, 2016; Jose & Medie, 2015). This includes securing or holding areas, establishing checkpoints, protecting settlements, and preventing insurgent infiltration (Schneckener, 2017, p. 808). We consider such functions part of broader civilian self-protection (Jose & Medie, 2015). Yet because militias often work alongside state forces to maintain political and social order, even without exclusive loyalty to the state (Jentzsch et al., 2015; Schubiger, 2021), they generally cooperate to protect civilians from insurgent violence, whether community-initiated or state-initiated (Jentzsch, 2022).

Because of their cooperation with the state forces, all communities hosting militias attract insurgent retaliatory violence (Aliyev, 2020; Clayton & Thomson, 2016). Militias with protective effects, especially those that coordinate effectively with state forces, can limit insurgent infiltration and help repel attacks, offering civilians durable protection that reduces rebel violence and exploitation. In contrast, militias lacking such capacity are less able to withstand rebel assaults and are more likely to collapse, leading to failed protection and ultimately leaving civilians exposed to severe and devastating violence.

We propose that community collective action capacity (hereinafter referred to as community capacity) helps explain whether a community forms a community-initiated militia or hosts a state-initiated one, and whether that militia can effectively protect civilians from insurgent violence. While community capacity includes several dimensions (Arjona, 2016; Kaplan, 2017; Mampilly, 2011; Van Baalen, 2021), we focus here on the role of local leadership and social cohesion, both of which are required for effective militia formation (Kaplan, 2017, p. 51). We expect local leadership and social cohesion to operate interactively rather than independently. Strong leadership without social cohesion may enable mobilization but undermine coordination and discipline, while high social cohesion without strong leadership may support social control yet limit the capacity to organize or sustain militia formation. Local leadership refers to traditional authorities, tribal elders, and influential religious figures who maintain local order alongside or in interaction with state institutions (al-Jabassini, 2024; Migdal, 2001). These actors mobilize residents for collective action through personal loyalty, legitimacy, or religious authority (Krause, 2018; Masullo, 2021; Van Baalen, 2021). Leadership varies across time and space, depending on leaders' ability to mobilize and provide social control.

Social cohesion refers to cooperative patterns among people living in close proximity, often linked to mutual welfare and the provision of public goods (Gilligan et al., 2014, p. 605). It comprises three core dimensions: social relations, identification with the local unit, and orientation toward the common good (Schiefer & Van Der Noll, 2017). Like leadership, social cohesion varies across communities, shaped by the quality of social bonds and the presence of local structures that support collective action (Arnon et al., 2023; Kaplan, 2017, p. 39). The importance of both leadership and cohesion is evident in rebel strategies to weaken them, such as targeting respected leaders or spreading rumors to erode trust and social control (Aguilar et al., 2024; Arjona, 2017, p. 765; Greenhill & Oppenheim, 2017).

We contend that high community capacity, marked by strong local leadership and high social cohesion, enables the emergence of effective community-initiated militias. These community-initiated militias, rely on social control, i.e. unwritten rules and norms, such as public censure, ostracism, and other communal sanctions, to regulate their behavior and pursue shared goals (Black, 1984; Janowitz, 1975). By contrast, state-initiated militias that are semi-formal or formal are governed by laws and policies and often resemble conventional security forces (Clayton & Thomson, 2016). Yet in many conflict-affected settings with weak state capacity, such as Syria, Mozambique, Cameroon, Guatemala,

and Peru, the state still establishes informal militias to bolster counterinsurgency efforts. These state-initiated informal militias maintain only loose ties to official forces but lack full state oversight (Agbiboa & Aniekwe, 2023; Bateson, 2017; Fumerton, 2001, 2018; Jentsch, 2022; Voller, 2022). Because communities that did not form community-initiated militias generally have low capacity, they find themselves in a very difficult position to develop social control over state-initiated militias.

Even before the insurgency, high-capacity communities engaged in activities to support, defend, and promote collective well-being (Finkel, 2017; Varshney, 2001). These communities benefit from strong leadership and longstanding networks of cooperation, reciprocity, and exchange, which foster social cohesion and enable collective action (Arnon et al., 2023). At the onset of irregular civil war, when state forces launch counterinsurgency operations, residents leverage this capacity to form militias organically (Fumerton, 2001; Schubiger, 2021). Strong local leadership facilitates gathering private information on prospective recruits' skills and motivations, enabling the enlistment of martially skilled and trustworthy members while screening out undesirable types (Forney, 2015; Jentsch, 2022; Koos, 2014). High social cohesion fosters mutual trust and a sense of shared interest, making residents readily see militia membership as a public good that delivers communal protection (Fumerton, 2001; Koos, 2014; Thomson, 2023). As local leaders and residents alike develop strong identification with these militias, they collectively enforce social control, through norms and sanctions, to ensure that militias act according to community expectations (Koos, 2014). This communal oversight helps militias maintain secrecy, prevent rebel infiltration, share intelligence, and secure credible protection from state forces during major attacks. In sum, high community capacity is crucial for the protective effects of community-initiated militias.

By contrast, communities with low capacity suffer from weak leadership and low social cohesion. Leaders in these areas often lack the authority or networks to mobilize residents, a problem sometimes exacerbated by the displacement or death of legitimate leaders during conflict (Aguilar et al., 2024). Daily interactions remain confined within family groups, and the absence of broader associational ties undermines the collective solidarity required in wartime (Arnon et al., 2023; Fumerton, 2001; Varshney, 2001). With weak leadership, militias only form when state forces impose them, appointing local commanders and often recruiting members by force (Estancona et al., 2019; Fumerton, 2001; Voller, 2023). Such haphazard recruitment yields poorly vetted militias, many driven by opportunism (Forney, 2015). Moreover, low social cohesion means rebels already enjoy numerous informants, raising the personal risk of militia membership. Faced with potential retaliation, most residents opt to remain neutral civilians rather than bear these costs. Without strong informal social controls, such as communal sanctions, militias struggle to organize, repel infiltrators, and prevent predation (Thomson, 2023). They therefore lack reliable local intelligence and operate outside state trust. When state forces suspect rebel infiltration, they withdraw support, further crippling these militias' ability to protect civilians from rebel violence. We present a schematic summary of our argument in Fig. 1 below.

4. Case selection and methods

We employ a sub-national research design focusing on north-eastern Nigeria. Using subnational controlled comparative case studies that leverage both similarities and differences, we selected two towns linked to militias (Seawright & Gerring, 2008, pp. 304–306; Tarrow, 2010, p. 245). Bama, hosting a state-initiated militia, experienced significant violence, while Bui, having formed a community-initiated militia, encountered less violence. We supplement the detailed comparative analysis of the two towns with illustrative examples from other towns and villages in the region. Fig. 2 provides geographic context by mapping Borno State and highlighting the two case study locations with vertical shading.

Our case selection involved four steps. First, we used the Armed Conflict Location & Event Data (ACLED) event data to analyze spatial and temporal variation in Boko Haram violence in north-eastern Nigeria from 2009 to 2021 (see appendix). Event data shows that Boko Haram's violence against civilians escalated between 2013 and 2015 and that Borno state, Boko Haram's birthplace, suffered the brunt of this violence. Second, we analyzed the spatial and temporal variation in rebel violence within Borno State from 2009 to 2013 and 2013 to 2015. While Boko Haram violence was limited to Maiduguri and a few other locations from 2009 to 2013, it spread to many other communities from 2013 to 2015. We focus on the two years of militia emergence between 2013 and 2015 because research has shown that violence against civilians is more prevalent during the formation of civilian militias (Clayton & Thomson, 2016). Furthermore, the Nigerian government formalized the operation of all militias by the end of 2015, with implications for militia effectiveness (see appendix). Next, we conducted desk research on the towns and villages to identify population estimates, ethnic composition, and distance to the capital, Maiduguri, all factors that may determine exposure to rebel violence (Skillicorn et al., 2021). Table 1 summarizes key characteristics of the selected cases. In the discussion section, we assess contextual factors such as religion, ethnicity, and geography, which were not held constant in the case selection, as potential alternative explanations. Despite these differences, we argue that conflict conditions and community capacity for collective action offer more convincing explanations for variation in militias' protective effects.

We draw on fieldwork in Maiduguri, Bui, and Bama, in addition to select other communities (Benisheikh, Ngamdu; see appendix for details) in Borno State, conducted during two months in June–August 2022. The first author's identity as a Nigerian national with many years of experience working in conflict zones facilitated safe and ethical research. The first author co-facilitated fourteen focus group discussions with six participants each, chosen from a similar demographic population (for example, women, young people, militia members), to understand different local perspectives and increase participants' ownership of the research process. In a conflict context like north-eastern Nigeria, where deep immersion may not always be the most ethical approach (Krause, 2021), these FGDs help us draw out many people's perspectives, which allows for triangulation of statements from which we draw inferences about community leadership and capacity, and social control over militias.

In addition, we conducted twenty individual interviews (selected using a purposive sampling technique) to collect information on local

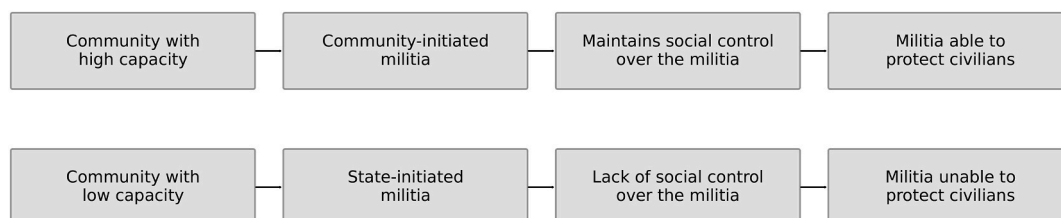


Fig. 1. Variation in militia formation and protective effects.

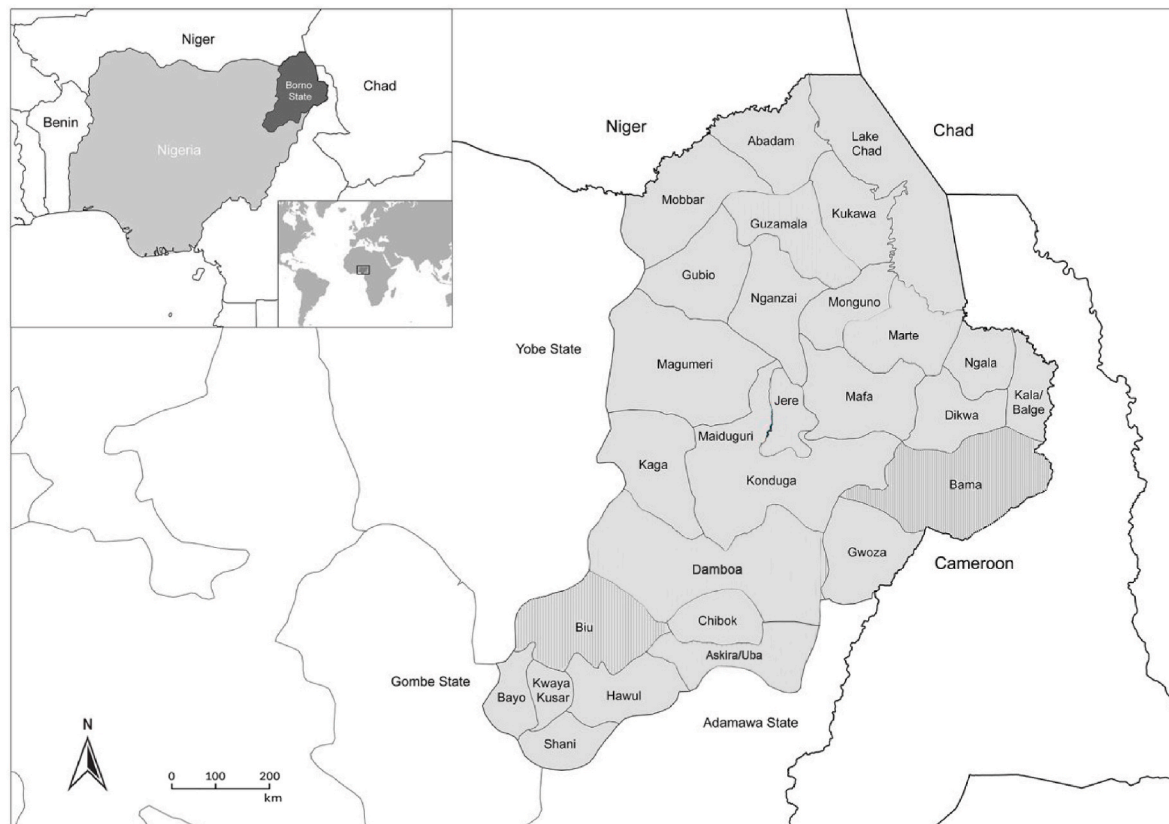


Fig. 2. Map of Borno State, Nigeria, highlighting the two cases (Biu and Bama) with vertical shading.

Table 1

Overview of the case comparison and findings.

	BIU	BAMA
Militia type	Community-initiated militia	State-initiated militia
Militia's protective effect	Durable protection	Failed protection
Independent variable		
Community capacity (local leadership and social cohesion)	High	Low
Contextual Characteristics		
Onset of the BH insurgency	Early 2010	Early 2010
Population estimates	246,900	379,500
Ethnicity	Bura-Pabir, Dera, Putai	Shuwa Arab, Kanuri, Maffa
Dominant Religion	Islam/Christianity	Islam
Distance to the capital	190.7 km	71.6 km
State forces presence	Yes	Yes
Difficult terrain	Yes	No
Proximity to border	No	Yes
Militia formation	July 2013	January 2014
BH fatalities (2009–2012)	10	6
BH fatalities (2013–2015)	48	216

conflict dynamics and militia activities. We interviewed representatives of Community-Based Organizations (CBOs), Non-Governmental Organizations (NGOs), traditional rulers, local authorities, journalists, conflict-affected and displaced people, and academics and conflict experts. We did not interview Boko Haram members due to safety and ethical concerns; instead, we reviewed Boko Haram's statements claiming responsibility for attacks (see appendix). All questions in FGDs and individual interviews were semi-structured and open-ended to allow for in-depth probing, with a series of prompts relating to the themes of community capacity, militia formation, militia activities, rebel group attack patterns, civilian victimization, and response to violence against civilians.

To analyze the FGDs and individual interview data, we used a combination of structural, process, and causal coding to identify explicit references to community characteristics shaping decisions to form militias, as well as evidence directly linking militia activities to protective effects against Boko Haram violence (see appendix). We confirmed the accuracy of respondents' accounts by cross-checking two or more sources (individual interviews or focus groups) across stakeholder groups (Kapiszewski et al., 2015). We analyze the two cases in three parts: (1) the protective effects of militias, (2) community capacity (including local leadership and social cohesion), and (3) mobilization and social control over militias. Before turning to the analysis, we provide background information on the Boko Haram insurgency and counterinsurgency in northeastern Nigeria.

5. Community-initiated militia formation and civilian protection in Biu

5.1. The protective effects of militias in Biu

Biu, the third largest town in Borno,² is one of the towns that formed a community-initiated CJTF militia, and the militia was successful in protecting civilians. They arrested Boko Haram members and repelled many insurgent attacks against the town. Before the formation of the militia in Biu, from 2010 to June 2013, Boko Haram primarily targeted clerics and government employees critical of the group through "silent killings," mostly at night or on the road. ACLED recorded 11 civilian fatalities within the town during that period (ACLED, 2022). One year after the formation of the CJTF, there were no recorded civilian casualties in Biu, as Boko Haram found it challenging to attack the city

² Residents of Biu and Bama both claimed that their town is the second largest, but according to official sources, Bama is the second largest.

directly. CJTF members that we interviewed recounted that they identified the few residents who joined Boko Haram and handed them over to state forces. For example, one of the CJTF leaders narrated a heroic account of how he led the arrest of a Boko Haram member in collaboration with the state military:

When we were trying to arrest one of the Boko Haram members, I went to the mosque that he uses to pray very early to be able to secure a spot close to him, and some military officers were waiting for me from outside. Immediately, I got close to him, I raised my hand, and they [the military] rushed to arrest him. He then started to name other members. At that moment alone, we arrested eight Boko Haram members, including a woman.³

Despite the arrest of the Boko Haram members within the town, Bui residents reported numerous attempted attacks, but the Bui CJTF successfully repelled them. Many residents understood the continuation of insurgent attacks as retaliation for forming the CJTF:

They attack communities that support CJTF or reject their offer of joining the group. They keep attacking them as punishment until they comply with them or stop supporting CJTF.⁴

They believe any community that forms CJTF is against them and hence everyone in such communities, including children, can be targeted.⁵

In 2014, Boko Haram encircled the town of Bui but faced strong resistance from the CJTF, with each attempted incursion into Bui and neighboring villages repelled (Otto, 2020). Residents explained, “sometimes they attack 3 to 4 times, and when they encounter significant resistance from the militia, they will leave.”⁶ Many of the attacks were carried out by well-armed insurgents approaching from forests. One resident recounted that he “saw flying bullets and heard heavy artillery sounds.”⁷ Even though collaboration with the state forces was vital for the CJTF to repel attacks, there were times when militiamen were the only ones who remained to defend the town. As one CJTF member recalled: “The military sometimes does not stay within the community after attacks; it is us, the CJTF, that stay.”⁸ Although state forces maintain a permanent presence in the town, when they and the CJTF repel assaults, Boko Haram often shifts its attacks to neighboring communities without state protection, prompting the military to launch offensives there. As a deceptive tactic, some Boko Haram fighters then slip back into Bui, only to be driven off again by the CJTF alone. To many of the CJTF, they believe they will do all they can to protect the town: “It is better for them to die in their ancestral home than in the bush or any other locations.”⁹ As a result of the CJTF's successful resistance, many people who had fled nearby communities settled within Bui seeking protection.¹⁰ *What explains the CJTF's ability to protect civilians in Bui?*

5.2. High community capacity in Bui

Local leaders were influential and proactive in community mobilization even before the insurgency. The prominent traditional leader, the late Emir of Bui - Alhaji Mai Umar Mustapha Aliyu (who ruled Bui for 31 years),¹¹ exerted significant influence over the community. His status

was enhanced in the eyes of many in Bui and surrounding areas due to his refusal to leave at the height of the insurgency, unlike many emirs in other towns and villages (D. Otto, 2020). He was said to declare, “If I leave Bui, it will be as a corpse. Better to die in my land than flee to Maiduguri [the state capital].”¹² Apart from the Emir, residents held other low-ranking traditional leaders and titleholders like Mai Anguwas (ward head) and Hakimis (district head) in high regard and emphasized their important roles in community mobilization.¹³ For example, they observed that the traditional youth leader, the Wakilin Matasa, “was actively mobilizing youth groups for community development projects and conflict prevention programs to unite them against Boko Haram.”¹⁴

Religious leaders also openly condemned Boko Haram's ideology and actions, preaching against them in public during the early days of the group's recruitment. In response to dwindling public support, Boko Haram conducted targeted assassinations of some of the clerics they accused of cooperating with security forces (Human Rights Watch, 2012, pp. 1–99). Unlike in other communities across Borno and other northern Nigerian states, where these targeted killings dissuaded many clerics from speaking out against Boko Haram (Olojo, 2017), traditional leaders, imams, and pastors in Bui organized prayers, preached security consciousness and united people, advocating for rejecting the insurgents unequivocally.¹⁵

Bui was well-known for its high social cohesion and proactive measures for conflict prevention, even before the insurgency (Monguno, 2017). The region's religious landscape was marked by the peaceful coexistence of two major religions: Christianity and Islam.¹⁶ Unlike in many parts of northcentral Nigeria, where both religions have been drawn into much communal violence, Bui's leaders valued religious tolerance and peaceful intergroup relationships (Usman, 2015, p. 416). Residents attributed the community's strong social cohesion to the mixed nature of families with Christian and Muslim members, and on leaders' emphasis on shared ethnicity as Babur/Bura.¹⁷ Similar emphasis on cross-cleavage social identities and “we-thinking” that enabled collective action to prevent violence has been observed in settings of ethno-religious conflict in Nigeria (Krause, 2018). In Bui, many interviewees described how the community engaged collectively to promote development and address security challenges. For example, some community organizations, neighborhood associations, occupation-based groups, and faith-based groups contributed to community development in areas such as education, peacebuilding, and conflict resolution.¹⁸ Residents believed that it was their responsibility to help each other.

Many respondents stated that it was primarily the *Yan Chirani*, migrant workers from northwestern Nigeria, whom Boko Haram attempted to recruit in Bui. These workers often travelled to Bui as farm laborers during the planting and harvest seasons. A significant number of them are *Almajiris*, young men from informal Qur'anic schools who took on itinerant work to support themselves. Some of these migrant workers later influenced and radicalized local youth to join the group.¹⁹ After the declaration of the state of emergency in May 2013, many residents cooperated with state forces to identify the insurgents; there were even cases of parents reporting their children's involvement with Boko Haram.²⁰

³ Interview with a CJTF member in Bui, July 22, 2022.

⁴ FGD with community residents in Bui, July 19, 2022.

⁵ Interview with a civil society activist in Bui, July 20, 2022.

⁶ Interview with a civil society activist in Bui, July 20, 2022.

⁷ FGD with community residents in Bui, July 19, 2022.

⁸ Interview with a CJTF member in Bui, July 25, 2022.

⁹ Interview with a civil society activist in Bui, July 20, 2022.

¹⁰ FGD with community residents in Bui, July 19, 2022.

¹¹ Alhaji Mai Umar Mustapha Aliyu died on September 14, 2020, at age 80 after a brief illness. Kingmakers in Bui appointed Midala Mustapha Umar, his eldest son, as the new emir.

¹² Interview with a community elder in Bui, July 18, 2022.

¹³ FGD with community residents in Bui, July 19, 2022.

¹⁴ Interview with a civil society rep in Bui, July 20, 2022.

¹⁵ FGD with community residents in Bui, July 19, 2022.

¹⁶ FGD with civil society in Bui, July 25, 2022.

¹⁷ Interviews with Bui residents, July 22, 2022.

¹⁸ Interview with community leader in Bui, July 19, 2022.

¹⁹ Interviews with Bui residents, July 22, 2022.

²⁰ FGD with civil society activists in Bui, July 20, 2022.

5.3. Mobilization and social control over militias in Biu

Just as in Maiduguri, the CJTF in Biu arose organically as a community initiative “out of rage, anger, and a desire to protect the community.”²¹ It was founded in July 2013 by young people with the strong support of traditional leaders during the days of mourning following the beheading of five people by Boko Haram.²² One interviewee narrated that some state forces personnel were given information by residents about the Boko Haram members who committed the killings. However, they said they could not locate the attackers. Residents feared that, “if they didn't take matters into their own hands, they'd meet the same fate as friends who had already lost their lives.”²³

Community leaders, pre-existing vigilantes, and hunter groups were all involved in the militia formation. While anyone could join voluntarily, to avoid infiltration by Boko Haram members and sympathizers, joining the militia required verification by traditional leaders, especially Mai Anguwa and Hakimi, “who checked their backgrounds and behaviors.”²⁴ The CJTF was under the social control of community leaders; members were subject to traditional accountability mechanisms, such as communal oversight and elders' mediation, which regulated their interactions with civilians. These mechanisms ensured discipline. Comprised mainly of men (and a few young women) organized into units of 50–60 lightly armed individuals, the CJTF was established and swiftly garnered prominence. They ensured that not only young men, but also older men participated actively. They patrolled the town on a shift basis. The militia also worked with and learned from the community's pre-existing vigilante and hunter groups. These traditional vigilantes shared their knowledge and skills with the CJTF, such as tracking techniques, interrogation methods, and traditional protective charms.

Other residents who were not CJTF members reported suspicious people who were new to the neighborhood. They also used traditional early warning methods such as burning firewood and blowing whistles to alert the CJTF of suspicious movements.²⁵ Sometimes, the Emir of Biu would buy and distribute firewood to different neighborhoods of the town “to burn them and stay awake.”²⁶ Residents remained alert and reported strange behavior to the CJTF, who would arrest suspected Boko Haram members.

When they [Boko Haram] try to run, the CJTF will chase them, even if they are carrying a gun. They are not scared for their lives.²⁷

The CJTF's close connection to the community made residents trust them and gave them maximum support to implement any security measure that aided community protection, while tolerating economic costs. For example, “planting crops was prohibited for more than six months in some neighborhoods so that the enemy [Boko Haram] would not have a hiding place.”²⁸ Many residents prayed that the CJTF would continue to fulfil their role of protecting the locality.

6. State-initiated militia formation and failed protection in Bama

6.1. The failed protection of militias in Bama

Bama, the second-largest town in Borno State, is one of the towns where state forces imposed a state-initiated militia. It has been one of

those hardest hits by the Boko Haram insurgency. Before the emergence of the militia in Bama, from 2010 to December 2013, few Boko Haram attacks against state forces and government officials took place. The emergence of the state-initiated CJTF in the town resulted in an escalation of insurgent attacks and violence against civilians (Amnesty International, 2015). Rather than providing protection, the CJTF proved ineffective in Bama, and its presence appears to have triggered repeated retaliatory attacks against civilians. Within a year of its formation, Bama experienced six attacks that resulted in 105 unarmed civilian deaths. These attacks were devastating, involving not only the killing of residents but also the widespread destruction of houses, shops, and other valuable property. For instance, on February 19, 2014, Boko Haram attacked Bama, resulting in the death of over 50 civilians (Raleigh et al., 2023). Residents stated:

They [Boko Haram] attacked because they were angry with the people for driving them out of town. That is why they attacked frequently; they wanted to kill as many people as possible and drive them out of town ... It was retaliation.²⁹

The frequency of insurgent violence in Bama and its surrounding villages increased almost weekly, culminating in the town's capture in September 2014. During the takeover, over 60 people were killed, and numerous houses, schools, and residential buildings were destroyed. An estimated 200,000 individuals were displaced to Maiduguri and other locations (OCHA, 2020). *What explains the failed protection of civilians by the CJTF in Bama?*

6.2. Low community capacity in Bama

According to residents interviewed, community leaders did not command the respect and trust of people in Bama. The authority of traditional leaders was contested due to the historical movement of the Dikwa Emirate to Bama by colonial officials in 1942, which resulted in the division of the town into Old Bama, where Gamergu indigenes lived, and other parts of the town that belonged to Kanuri settlers (Monguno, 2017). The settlers had a strong attachment to the Late Shehu of Bama - Alhai Kyari Ibn Umar El-Kanemi³⁰ and other traditional leaders, with most residents in Old Bama, particularly young people, having little regard for them (Monguno, 2017). Traditional leaders were seen as corrupt and neglecting the community's needs:

They only focus on the benefits attached to their positions. They are all selfish, especially the Lawans [district heads]. We disagree with them, but we have no choice but to accept them as our leaders.³¹

When the insurgency began, many traditional and religious leaders fled Bama, while insurgents targeted others for their refusal to collaborate. Community capacity was also low due to a lack of community-based organizations that could have prevented youth from joining the insurgency.³² Boko Haram exploited the situation to recruit members and demand compliance. One militia member recalled that during the start of the insurgency, some residents even celebrated and supported the insurgents:

There were many sympathizers during the start of the insurgency, and they celebrated Boko Haram when they were attacking government facilities. When Boko Haram murdered people, they praised them, saying, ‘Wow, that is great they assassinated CID [Criminal

²¹ FGD with CJTF members in Biu, July 22, 2022.

²² Interviews with Biu residents, July 22, 2022.

²³ Interview with a CJTF member in Biu, July 18, 2022.

²⁴ FGD with CJTF members in Biu, July 22, 2022.

²⁵ FGD with residents in Biu, July 19, 2022.

²⁶ FGD with residents Biu, July 19, 2022.

²⁷ Interviews with community leaders in Biu, July 23, 2022.

²⁸ FGD with residents in Biu, July 23, 2022.

²⁹ FGD with residents Biu, July 19, 2022.

³⁰ Alhai Kyari Ibn Umar El-Kanemi (who ruled for over 30 years) died on 27 April 2020 while still in exile in Maiduguri. His eldest son, Alhai Umar Ibn Kyari Al Amin El-Kanemi, has been appointed the new Emir of Bama.

³¹ Interview with a youth leader in Bama, July 16, 2022.

³² Interview with a community Leader Bama, July 14, 2022.

Investigation Department operatives].’ When they murder someone, they say, ‘Great, that is SS [State Security] or Police.’³³

This early sympathy stemmed from Boko Haram’s propaganda about remedying state injustices and its targeting of the police, whom residents viewed as corrupt and prone to demanding bribes at checkpoints.³⁴ However, this sympathy did not translate into widespread enlistment, as it did in other contexts (Wood, 2003). In May 2013, after the state of emergency was declared, state forces responded with harsh counterinsurgency measures, imposing movement restrictions, curfews, and human rights violations, including false accusations of Boko Haram membership. One of the residents recalled:

The time when the curfews were imposed was terrible because many people lost their lives. Soldiers raided homes, arrested many people, and killed some.³⁵

The harsh counterinsurgency prompted Boko Haram to begin targeting unarmed local populations, who had previously been spared, for perceived complicity in arrests. As Boko Haram widened its killings in Bama, even early sympathizers withdrew their support.³⁶ Yet these same counterinsurgency measures also weakened the community’s capacity and its relationship with state forces. For example, as part of the town’s counterinsurgency operations, traditional anti-crime vigilantes such as Yan Banga, Kesh-kesh, and hunters, who had existed in Bama for many years before the insurgency, had all their weapons confiscated or were forced to flee. A CJTF leader in Bama explained:

Even before the CJTF, we had Yan Banga fighting criminality in the town. However, during the height of the insurgency, they concealed their weapons out of fear of Boko Haram. It is sometimes the military that seizes all local firearms. When the military sees you with a gun, even a local hunting gun, they will beat you up and take the gun away. Many hunters and Yan Banga either fled or buried their firearms.³⁷

6.3. Poor mobilization and lack of social control over militias in Bama

After dismissing pre-existing vigilantes a year earlier, in January 2014 state military forces coerced residents into forming a CJTF to defend the town. This recruitment was forced, as many residents feared joining, because Boko Haram had explicitly threatened to kill anyone who enlisted or openly cooperated with state forces. One CJTF member explained the recruitment process:

When they arrived from Maiduguri, they chose one representative from each neighborhood. The representatives ensured that no young person would flee [to avoid joining the CJTF], and if you did, you would be accused of supporting Boko Haram.³⁸

The primary objective of the CJTF was to support the state forces and serve as their “eyes and ears,” to facilitate the identification and apprehension of Boko Haram members, and to safeguard civilians.³⁹ Unlike the grassroots-driven, community-initiated CJTF in Biu, in Bama the militia was primarily organized by state forces. Because most community leaders had fled the town, they were not involved in the recruitment, leaving state forces without reliable local leadership to mobilize and screen new CJTF members. One civil society activist explained: “You just needed to take a weapon or stick to identify as a

CJTF member.”⁴⁰ The CJTF’s disorganized nature and lack of social control raised suspicions that insurgents had infiltrated the group. These suspicions only fuelled mistrust between state forces and the community.

When the CJTF started, there were suspicions that some Boko Haram members infiltrated the group. Some soldiers accused us of working together with Boko Haram.⁴¹

Rather than safeguarding unarmed civilians, some of the CJTF members denounced and falsely accused some innocent individuals of collaborating with Boko Haram due to personal vendettas and other motives. They also committed sexual assault:

They set up illegal detention centers, similar to military detention centers at the time, where they detain people accused of supporting Boko Haram. Many innocent people have been arrested, and vulnerable women and girls have been sexually harassed.⁴²

The lack of community leaders’ social control over the Bama CJTF allowed militia members to commit grave human rights violations against civilians. Militia violence against unarmed community members further eroded community support and militia effectiveness in protecting civilians. Because state forces believed that some CJTF members sold intelligence to Boko Haram, they would retreat from the front lines, leaving the town unprotected in the wake of insurgent attacks. As one of the Bama residents alleged: “The soldiers guarding us just went away as the insurgents advanced against our town.”⁴³ The lack of trust and cooperation with state forces and community leaders made it impossible for the Bama CJTF to protect civilians against Boko Haram violence.

7. Discussion

Variation in civilian militia formation and protection effectiveness, as seen in Biu and Bama, reflects broader patterns across many state-dominated communities in northeastern Nigeria (Amnesty International, 2015; CIVIC, 2018). In such settings, state forces maintain predominant control by operating checkpoints and actively searching for Boko Haram members and informants. Yet they remain insufficient to prevent rebel infiltration and attacks without intelligence and manpower support from local residents (Sanda, 2020). This shortfall stems largely from Nigeria’s centralized security structure, which deploys federal forces to unfamiliar communities. For militias to be effective under these conditions, they require both state security presence and high community capacity to exert social control and manage relations with the military. Despite this, the military has routinely encouraged or imposed militia formation even in communities lacking these conditions, thereby reshaping the geography of violence in the region.

As part of its counter-insurgency strategy, the military has pushed for all communities in the conflict zone, including those in contested areas where they lack sustained control, to form militias. Communities that refuse or reject state-imposed militias are often labeled as ‘Boko Haram communities’ and subjected to harsher counter-insurgency measures (Buba, 2024). By mid-2014, the military had encouraged or imposed the formation of CJTF units in more than 25 communities across Borno State. Many of these failed to protect civilians either because they were imposed in low-capacity communities or because, despite high capacity, they operated in contested zones without sustained state presence, leaving civilians vulnerable to rebel retaliation. In Gamboru Ngala, a state-dominated town with low community capacity, state forces created a CJTF unit and compelled residents to join in May 2014. Soon

³³ FGD with CJTF members in Bama, July 17, 2022.

³⁴ Interview with CJTF leader in Bama, July 17, 2022.

³⁵ Interview with Bama resident, July 15, 2022.

³⁶ FGD with Bama residents, July 16, 2022.

³⁷ Interview with CJTF leader in Bama, July 17, 2022.

³⁸ FGD with CJTF members in Bama, July 17, 2022.

³⁹ Interviews with CJTF member in Maiduguri, June 29, 2022.

⁴⁰ Interview with CSO member in Bama, July 16, 2022.

⁴¹ Interview with a CJTF leader in Bama, June 29, 2022.

⁴² Interview with a community resident in Bama, July 15, 2022.

⁴³ FGD with Bama residents, July 16, 2022.

after, on May 5–6, 2014, Boko Haram launched a deadly assault, overwhelming the militia and killing more than 300 civilians (Amnesty International, 2015; BBC News, 2014). Respondents noted the absence of social control over the militia, with deep mistrust between the community, traditional leaders, and state forces.

Guzamala illustrates the opposite case: a high-capacity community located in a contested area without a permanent state presence. In December 2013, the military encouraged residents to form a CJTF. Unlike imposed formations, Guzamala's residents, led by elders, began mobilizing the militia themselves. However, soon after mobilization began, Boko Haram attacked and issued a warning to halt the effort. The community subsequently abandoned the CJTF formation and turned to a dual compliance strategy, discreetly accommodating both Boko Haram and state forces without either side's knowledge (Buba, 2024).

Three potential alternative explanations for variation in militias' protective effects that are not controlled for in case selection merit consideration: geography, religion, and ethnicity. If terrain features such as surrounding hills that hinder insurgent movement were decisive (Dowd, 2017; Monguno & Umara, 2023), Boko Haram should have struggled to capture Gwoza, which shares similar geography with Biu. Yet Gwoza, a state-dominated area with a state-initiated militia, was attacked repeatedly in June 2014 and occupied by August. By contrast, Biu repelled multiple attacks, owing to effective coordination between a community-initiated CJTF and state forces. Distance from the capital also offers limited explanatory power. Although Bama is closer to Maiduguri than Biu and should therefore have been a higher state priority, it experienced severe violence. A related geographic argument points to the proximity of Gwoza and Bama to the Cameroon border, where Boko Haram was expanding its operations at the time. However, border proximity alone cannot explain why Boko Haram also attacked towns that are far from border areas, such as Damboa and Benisheikh, only a few miles away from Maiduguri. Taken together, these patterns suggest that geography is an important contextual factor, but it cannot sufficiently account for the observed variation in militias' protective effects.

Regarding ethnicity and religion, some scholars interpret Boko Haram as a Kanuri-led effort to revive the Islamic kingdom of Kanem-Borno (Pieri & Zenn, 2017). If kinship ties or shared ideology explained the weakness of state-imposed militias, Boko Haram would likely have spared Bama's population. Yet the group targeted civilians there despite these affinities (Thurston, 2018). Residents noted that the absence of strong community-initiated militias was not due to ideological alignment but to weak community capacity. Moreover, if ethnicity or religion were decisive, militias would not have first emerged in Maiduguri, which, like Bama, is predominantly Kanuri, Shuwa Arab, and Muslim.

Lastly, our single-case study may raise concerns about generalizability (Gerring, 2004). While our theory was built from fine-grained fieldwork observations collected in north-eastern Nigeria, we contend that our theory may 'translate' (Simmons & Smith, 2025) to militia formation in other contexts of counterinsurgency, such as Cameroon and the Niger Republic. In Cameroon's Far North region, civilians formed the community-initiated comité de vigilance (vigilante committee) in early 2014 to combat the jihadist insurgency, as state forces proved inadequate. Upon their success, the state initiated the formation of vigilante committees across the region (Agbibo & Aniekwe, 2023). Community leaders created their own Comité de Vigilance through rigorous vetting processes that ensured social control, but state-initiated committees lacked proper recruitment (Edongo & Elom, 2019; International Crisis Group, 2017, pp. 1–37). Reports indicated that Cameroonian soldiers pressured men and boys to join state-initiated militias, often accusing those who refused of being jihadist members and threatening them (US Department of State, 2021). Militia formation resulted in an escalation of insurgent violence against civilians, most notably against state-initiated comités de vigilance (Agbibo & Aniekwe, 2023; International Crisis Group, 2017, pp. 1–37). By contrast, in the Niger

Republic, authorities allowed pre-existing vigilante and hunter groups to continue operating and protect civilians against insurgent violence on the condition of sharing information with formal security and law enforcement agencies (International Crisis Group, 2017, pp. 1–37). Compared to Nigeria and Cameroon, communities in the Niger Republic faced less violence from jihadist insurgents.

8. Conclusion

This article provides both a theoretical and empirical foundation for understanding how militia formation shapes civilian protection in conflict zones. Drawing on fieldwork and theory, we argue that in state-dominated areas, repressive conflict conditions, marked by rebel infiltration, indiscriminate state violence, and the breakdown of neutrality, create powerful incentives for communities to form militias. Whether a community does so on its own initiative or instead hosts state-imposed militias depends on its collective action capacity, notably the strength of local leadership and the degree of social cohesion. Communities with high capacity tend to establish community-initiated militias and maintain social control over them, thereby offering civilians a degree of protection. In contrast, communities with low capacity are more likely to host state-imposed militias over which they exercise little or no control, resulting in ill-disciplined militias, insurgent infiltration, distrust from security forces, and ultimately failed protection of civilians.

Our findings make three key contributions. First, we advance the literature on civilian agency and self-protection (Jose & Medie, 2015; Krause et al., 2023) by demonstrating that community characteristics that predict nonviolence, such as neutrality and autonomy (Kaplan, 2017), also predict the emergence of militias with protective capacity against rebels. Second, we contribute to research on militias in civil war (Blocq, 2014; Clayton & Thomson, 2016; Jentzsch, 2022; Koos, 2014; Shire, 2021) by offering nuance on the effects of militia formation on rebel violence. While existing work suggests that militia formation intensifies violence and prolongs conflict (Aliyev, 2020; Carey & González, 2021; Clayton & Thomson, 2016; Steinert et al., 2019), our findings indicate that the protective effects of militias hinges on their origins and communities' social control over their activities. This addresses recent calls (Carey & Mitchell, 2017; Jentzsch, 2023b) to differentiate militias by their social and institutional embeddedness when assessing their impact.

Third, our analysis contributes to research on changing patterns of political violence (Gutiérrez-Sanín & Wood, 2017; Kalyvas, 2019). Before militia formation, insurgents relied on targeted "silent killings", especially of traditional and religious leaders, and abductions. The formation of militias escalated the conflict, resulting in vastly more destructive insurgent attacks on unarmed civilians. While some studies attributed Boko Haram's attack patterns primarily to geography or strategic location (Dowd, 2017; Monguno & Umara, 2023), we show instead that militia formation and militia protective effects also account for the escalation and variation in impact of Boko Haram violence across the region. This analysis underscores how civilian actions can transform insurgent violence.

Our findings open important avenues for further inquiry: What self-protection strategies do communities adopt when state-initiated militias fail to provide adequate protection? To what extent are insurgents aware of the emergence and protection potential of community-initiated militias, and does this knowledge influence their decisions to target or avoid specific communities? How does communities' social control over militias change once the state coopts and formalizes them? Finally, what are the long-term legacies of militia formation in conflict settings? There remains much to uncover. Importantly, our findings underscore the potential perils of attempting to (forcefully) transplant effective civilian self-protection strategies, such as community-initiated militias, across conflict zones.

CRediT authorship contribution statement

Imrana Buba: Writing – review & editing, Writing – original draft, Methodology, Investigation, Data curation, Conceptualization, Project administration. **Jana Krause:** Writing – review & editing, Supervision, Project administration, Methodology, Funding acquisition, Conceptualization, Writing – original draft.

Ethics and informed consent

Ethical approvals for the Nigerian fieldwork were obtained from the European Research Council's ethics commission (852816), the Nigerian National Health Research Ethics Committee (NHREC/01/01/2007-13/05/2022), and the Norwegian Agency for Shared Services in Education and Research (702762). Due to low levels of literacy in the area and risks associated with the collection of names and signatures, we asked residents for verbal consent only without signing the official consent forms (in line with our ethics approval). We submit a detailed appendix explaining the research process and ethical considerations along with the article manuscript for review.

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Declaration of competing interest

The authors declare that they have no known competing financial interests or personal relationships that could have appeared to influence the work reported in this paper.

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Appendix A. Supplementary data

Supplementary data to this article can be found online at <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.polgeo.2026.103497>.

Data availability

The authors do not have permission to share data.

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